

brought to India by the Mughals in the 16th century. It uses flat and flexible metallic threads called badla to add shiny accents to Chikankari creations. He pulls out a saree that took a whole two years to make, as I marvel at the twists and turns in the metallic threads which create a beautiful shimmering effect.

According to Bhandari: "Today there are just a few kamdani artists left in Lucknow, most of them are above the age of 60. I am attempting to keep the art form alive for as long as I can. It is a responsibility that I have as a designer." She is just one of the many revivalists who are keeping these art forms alive. For many of India's erstwhile royals, patronising artists and artisans was part and parcel of daily court life and, in a way, giving back to society. Art forms like Chikankari, kamdani, meenakari, block prints and zardozi thrived in these courts.

Across the state of Uttar Pradesh, in the city of

